

‘What is it?’

‘Well, I don’t suppose there’s anything in it, but it’s rather curious.’

He retailed the conversation at tea the day before.

‘So Sir Oswald Coore is ambidextrous?’ said Bundle.

‘Yes. And I remember now on that night at Chimneys—you know, the night Gerry Wade died—I was watching the bridge and thinking idly how awkwardly someone was dealing—and then realizing that it was because they were dealing with the left hand. Of course, it must have been Sir Oswald.’

They all three looked at each other. Loraine shook her head.

‘A man like Sir Oswald Coore! It’s impossible. What could he have to gain by it?’

‘It seems absurd,’ said Jimmy. ‘And yet—’

‘No 7 has his own ways of working,’ quoted Bundle softly. ‘Supposing this is the way Sir Oswald has really made his fortune?’

‘But why stage all that comedy at the Abbey when he’d had the formula at his own works?’

‘There might be ways of explaining that,’ said Loraine. ‘The same line of argument you used about Mr O’Rourke. Suspicion had to be diverted from him and placed in another quarter.’

Bundle nodded eagerly.

‘It all fits in. Suspicion is to fall on Bauer and the Countess. Who on earth would ever dream of suspecting Sir Oswald Coore?’

‘I wonder if Bartle does,’ said Jimmy slowly.

Some chord of memory vibrated in Bundle’s mind. *Superintendent Bartle plucking an ivy leaf off the millionaire’s coat.*

Had Bartle suspected all the time?

Chapter XXIX

Singular Behaviour of George Lomax

‘Mr Lomax is here, my lord.’

Lord Caterham started violently, for, absorbed in the intricacies of what not to do with the left wrist, he had not heard the butler approach over the soft turf. He looked at Tredwell more in sorrow than in anger.

‘I told you at breakfast, Tredwell, that I should be particularly engaged this morning.’

‘Yes, my lord, but—’

‘Go and tell Mr Lomax that you have made a mistake, that I am out in the village, that I am laid up with the gout, or, if all else fails, that I am dead.’

‘Mr Lomax, my lord, has already caught sight of your lordship when driving up the drive.’

Lord Caterham sighed deeply.

‘He would. Very well, Tredwell, I am coming.’ In a manner highly characteristic, Lord Caterham was always most genial when his feelings were in reality the reverse. He greeted George now with a heartiness quite unparalleled.

‘My dear fellow, my dear fellow. Delighted to see you. Absolutely delighted. Sit down. Have a drink. Well, well, this is splendid!’

And having pushed George into a large arm-chair, he sat down opposite him and blinked nervously.

‘I wanted to see you very particularly,’ said George.

‘Oh!’ said Lord Caterham faintly, and his heart sank, whilst his mind raced actively over all the dread possibilities that might lie behind that simple phrase.

'Very particularly,' said George with heavy emphasis.

Lord Caterham's heart sank lower than ever. He felt that something was coming worse than anything he had yet thought of.

'Yes?' he said, with a courageous attempt at nonchalance.

'Is Eileen at home?'

Lord Caterham felt reprieved, but slightly surprised.

'Yes, yes,' he said. 'Bundle's here. Got that friend of hers with her—the little Wade girl. Very nice girl—*very* nice girl. Going to be quite a good golfer one day. Nice easy swing—'

He was chatting garrulously on when George interrupted with ruthlessness:

'I am glad Eileen is at home. Perhaps I might have an interview with her presently?'

'Certainly, my dear fellow, certainly.' Lord Caterham still felt very surprised, but was still enjoying the sensation of reprieve. 'If it doesn't bore you.'

'Nothing could bore me less,' said George. 'I think, Caterham, if I may say so, that you hardly appreciate the fact that Eileen is grown up. She is no longer a child. She is a woman, and if I may say so, a very charming and talented woman. The man who succeeds in winning her love will be extremely lucky. I repeat it—extremely lucky.'

'Oh, I daresay,' said Lord Caterham. 'But she's very restless, you know. Never content to be in one place for more than two minutes together. However, I daresay young fellows don't mind that nowadays.'

'You mean that she is not content to stagnate. Eileen has brains, Caterham; she is ambitious. She interests herself in the questions of the day, and brings her fresh and vivid young intellect to bear upon them.'

Lord Caterham stared at him. It occurred to him that what was so often referred to as 'the strain of modern life,' had begun to tell upon George. Certainly his description of Bundle seemed to Lord Caterham ludicrously unlike.

'Are you sure you are feeling quite well?' he asked anxiously.

George waved the inquiry aside impatiently.

'Perhaps, Caterham, you begin to have some inkling of my purpose in visiting you this morning. I am not a man to undertake fresh responsibilities lightly. I have a proper sense, I hope, of what is due to the position I hold. I have given this matter my deep and earnest consideration. Marriage, especially

'It's nice to know we all get money for nothing sometimes,' she murmured to Jimmy.

The three stood together in the road, silent for the moment as they each pondered the situation.

'I know,' said Bundle suddenly.

'Know what?'

'Something I meant to ask you—and nearly forgot. Do you remember that glove that Superintendent Bartle found—the half-burnt one?'

'Yes.'

'Didn't you say that he tried it on your hand?'

'Yes—it was a shade big. That fits in with the idea of its being a big, hefty man who wore it.'

'That's not at all what I'm bothering about. Never mind the size of it. George and Sir Oswald were both there too, weren't they?'

'Yes.'

'He could have given it to either of them to fit on?'

'Yes, of course—'

'But he didn't. He chose you. Jimmy, don't you see what that means?'

Mr Theisiger stared at her.

'I'm sorry, Bundle. Possibly the jolly old brain isn't functioning as well as usual, but I haven't the faintest idea what you're talking about.'

'Don't you see, Loraine?'

Loraine looked at her curiously, but shook her head. 'Does it mean anything in particular?'

'Of course it does. Don't you see—Jimmy had his right hand in a sling.'

'By Jove, Bundle,' said Jimmy slowly. 'It was rather odd now I come to think of it; it's being a left hand glove, I mean. Bartle never said anything.'

'He wasn't going to draw attention to it. By trying it on you it might pass without notice being drawn to it, and he talked about the size just to put everybody off. But surely it must mean that the man who shot at you held the pistol in his *left* hand.'

'So we've got to look for a left-handed man,' said Loraine thoughtfully.

'Yes, and I'll tell you another thing. That was what Bartle was doing looking through the golf clubs. He was looking for a left-handed man's.'

'By Jove,' said Jimmy suddenly.

'Dangerous? Of course he's not dangerous. Fancy Pongo being dangerous. He's an ass. But, as I said just now, he's an ubiquitous ass. He doesn't even seem to need sleep like ordinary mortals. In fact, to put it bluntly, the fellow's a damned nuisance.'

And, in a somewhat aggrieved manner, Jimmy described the events of the previous evening.

Bundle was not very sympathetic.

'I don't know what you think you're doing anyway, mouching round here.' 'N° 7,' said Jimmy crisply. 'That's what I'm after. N° 7.'

'And you think you'll find him in this house?'

'I thought I might find a clue.'

'And you didn't?'

'Not last night—no.'

'But this morning,' said Loraine, breaking in suddenly. 'Jimmy, you did find something this morning. I can see it by your face.'

'Well, I don't know if it is anything. But during the course of my stroll—'

'Which stroll didn't take you far from the house, I imagine.'

'Strangely enough, it didn't. Round trip in the interior, we might call it. Well, as I say, I don't know whether there's anything in it or not. But I found this.'

With the celerity of a conjuror he produced a small bottle and tossed it over to the girls. It was half full of a white powder.

'What do you think it is?' asked Bundle.

'A white crystalline powder, that's what it is,' said Jimmy. 'And to any reader of detective fiction those words are both familiar and suggestive. Of course, if it turns out to be a new kind of patent tooth-powder, I shall be chagrined and annoyed.'

'Where did you find it?' asked Bundle sharply.

'Ah!' said Jimmy, 'that's my secret.'

And from that point he would not budge in spite of cajolery and insult.

'Here we are at the garage,' he said. 'Let's hope the high-mettled Hispano has not been subjected to any indignities.'

The gentleman at the garage presented a bill for five shillings and made a few vague remarks about loose nuts. Bundle paid him with a sweet smile.

at my age, is not to be undertaken without full—er—consideration. Equality of birth, similarity of tastes, general suitability, and the same religious creed—all these things are necessary and the pros and cons have to be weighed and considered. I can, I think, offer my wife a position in society that is not to be despised. Eileen will grace that position admirably. By birth and breeding she is fitted for it, and her brains and her acute political sense cannot but further my career to our mutual advantage. I am aware, Caterham, that there is—er—some disparity in years. But I can assure you that I feel full of vigour—in my prime. The balance of years should be on the husband's side. And Eileen has serious tastes—an older man will suit her better than some young jackanapes without either experience or *savoir-faire*. I can assure you, my dear Caterham, that I will cherish her—er—exquisite youth; I will cherish it—er—it will be appreciated. To watch the exquisite flower of her mind unfolding—what a privilege! And to think that I never realized—'

He shook his head deprecatingly and Lord Caterham, finding his voice with difficulty, said blankly:

'Do I understand you to mean—ah, my dear fellow, you can't want to marry Bundle?'

'You are surprised. I suppose to you it seems sudden. I have your permission, then, to speak to her?'

'Oh, yes,' said Lord Caterham. 'If it's permission you want—of course you can. But you know, Lomax, I really shouldn't if I were you. Just go home and think it over like a good fellow. Count twenty. All that sort of thing. Always a pity to propose and make a fool of yourself.'

'I daresay you mean your advice kindly, Caterham, though I must confess that you put it somewhat strangely. But I have made up my mind to put my fortune to the test. I may see Eileen?'

'Oh, it's nothing to do with me,' said Lord Caterham hastily; 'Eileen settles her own affairs. If she came to me to-morrow and said she was going to marry the chauffeur, I shouldn't make any objections. It's the only way nowadays. Your children can make life damned unpleasant if you don't give in to them in every way. I say to Bundle, 'Do as you like, but don't worry me,' and really, on the whole, she is amazingly good about it.'

George stood up, intent upon his purpose. 'Where shall I find her?'

'Well, really, I don't know,' said Lord Caterham vaguely. 'She might be anywhere. As I told you just now, she's never in the same place for two minutes together. No repose.'

'And I suppose Miss Wade will be with her? It seems to me, Caterham, that the best plan would be for you to ring the bell and ask your butler to find her, saying that I wish to speak to her for a few minutes.'

Lord Caterham pressed the bell obediently.

'Oh, Tredwell,' he said, when the bell was answered, 'just find her ladyship, will you? Tell her Mr Lomax is anxious to speak to her in the drawing-room.'

'Yes, my lord.'

Tredwell withdrew. George seized Lord Caterham's hand and wrung it warmly, much to the latter's discomfort.

'A thousand thanks,' he said. 'I hope soon to bring you good news.'

He hastened from the room.

'Well,' said Lord Caterham. 'Well!'

And after a long pause:

'What *has* Bundle been up to?'

The door opened again.

'Mr Eversleigh, my lord.'

As Bill hastened in, Lord Caterham caught his hand and spoke earnestly.

'Hullo, Bill. You're looking for Lomax, I suppose? Look here, if you want to do a good turn, hurry into the drawing-room and tell him the Cabinet have called an immediate meeting, or get him away somehow. It's really not fair to let the poor devil make an ass of himself all for some silly girl's prank.'

'I've not come for Codders,' said Bill. 'Didn't know he was here. It's Bundle I want to see. Is she anywhere about?'

'You can't see her,' said Lord Caterham. 'Not just now, at any rate. George is with her.'

'Well—what does it matter?'

'I think it does rather,' said Lord Caterham. 'He's probably spluttering horribly at this minute, and we mustn't do anything to make it worse for him.'

'But what is he saying?'

'Heavens knows,' said Lord Caterham. 'A lot of damned nonsense, anyway. Never say too much, that was always my motto. Grab the girl's hand and let events take their course.'

Just then Jimmy Thesiger strolled round the corner of the house. 'Bundle, by all that's wonderful!' he exclaimed.

'You've missed competing in the Autumn Meeting,' said O'Rourke. 'I'd gone for a stroll,' said Jimmy. 'Where did these girls drop from?'

'We came on our flat feet,' said Bundle. 'The Hispano let us down.'

And she narrated the circumstances of the breakdown.

Jimmy listened with sympathetic attention.

'Hard luck,' he vouchsafed. 'If it's going to take some time, I'll run you back in my car after lunch.'

A gong sounded at that moment and they all went in. Bundle observed Jimmy covertly. She thought she had noticed an unusual note of exultance in his voice. She had the feeling that things had gone well.

After lunch they took a polite leave of Lady Coote, and Jimmy volunteered to run them down to the garage in his car. As soon as they had started the same word burst simultaneously from both girls' lips:

'Well?'

Jimmy chose to be provoking.

'Well?'

'Oh, pretty hearty, thanks. Slight indigestion owing to over indulgence in dry biscuits.'

'But what has happened?'

'I tell you. Devotion to the cause made me eat too many dry biscuits. But did our hero flinch? No, he did not.'

'Oh, Jimmy,' said Loraine reproachfully, and he softened.

'What do you really want to know?'

'Oh, everything. Didn't we do it well? I mean, the way we kept Pongo and Terence O'Rourke in play.'

'I congratulate you on the handling of Pongo. O'Rourke was probably a sitter—but Pongo is made of other stuff. There's only one word for that lad—it was in the *Sunday News* bag cross-word last week. Word of ten letters meaning everywhere at once. Ubiquitous. That describes Pongo down to the ground. You can't go anywhere without running into him—and the worst of it is you never hear him coming.'

'You think he's dangerous?'

'It must have been someone else, Miss Wade. Though, as a matter of fact, I do happen to know—'

'What a wonderful young man you are,' interrupted Loraine. 'You know about everything.'

'One should keep abreast of modern knowledge,' said Mr Bateman seriously.

'Now about your dog's paws—'

Terence O'Rourke murmured *sotto voce* to Bundle:

'It is a man like that that writes all those little paragraphs in the weekly papers. "It is not generally known that to keep a brass fender uniformly bright," etc.; "The dorper beetle is one of the most interesting characters in the insect world"; "The marriage customs of the Fingalese Indians," and so on.'

'General information, in fact.'

'And what more horrible two words could you have?' said Mr O'Rourke, and added piously: 'Thank the Heavens above I'm an educated man and know nothing whatever upon any subject at all.'

'I see you've got clock golf here,' said Bundle to Lady Coote.

'I'll take you on at it, Lady Eileen,' said O'Rourke.

'Let's challenge those two,' said Bundle. 'Loraine, Mr O'Rourke and I want to take you and Mr Bateman on at clock golf.'

'Do play, Mr Bateman,' said Lady Coote, as the secretary showed a momentary hesitation. 'I'm sure Sir Oswald doesn't want you.'

The four went out on the lawn.

'Very cleverly managed, what?' whispered Bundle to Loraine. 'Congratulations on our girlish tact.'

The round ended just before one o'clock, victory going to Bateman and Loraine.

'But I think you'll agree with me, partner,' said Mr O'Rourke, 'that we played a more sporting game.'

He lagged a little behind with Bundle.

'Old Pongo's a cautious player—he takes no risks. Now, with me it's neck or nothing. And a fine motto through life, don't you agree, Lady Eileen?' 'Hasn't it ever landed you in trouble?' asked Bundle, laughing.

'To be sure it has. Millions of times. But I'm still going strong. Sure, it'll take the hangman's noose to defeat Terence O'Rourke.'

Bill stared at him.

'But look here, sir, I'm in a hurry. I must talk to Bundle—'

'Well, I don't suppose you'll have to wait long. I must confess I'm rather glad to have you here with me—I suppose Lomax will insist on coming back and talking to me when it's all over.'

'When what's all over? What is Lomax supposed to be doing?'

'Hush,' said Lord Caterham. 'He's proposing.'

'Proposing? Proposing what?'

'Marriage. To Bundle. Don't ask me why. I suppose he's come to what they call the dangerous age. I can't explain it any other way.'

'Proposing to Bundle? The dirty swine. At his age.'

Bill's face grew crimson.

'He says he's in the prime of life,' said Lord Caterham cautiously.

'He? Why, he's decrepit—senile! I—' Bill positively choked.

'Not at all,' said Lord Caterham coldly. 'He's five years younger than I am.'

'Of all the damned cheek! Codders and Bundle! A girl like Bundle! You oughtn't to have allowed it.'

'I never interfere,' said Lord Caterham.

'You ought to have told him what you thought of him.'

'Unfortunately modern civilization rules that out,' said Lord Caterham regretfully. 'In the Stone Age now—but, dear me, I suppose even then I shouldn't be able to do it—being a small man.'

'Bundle! Bundle! Why, I've never dared to ask Bundle to marry me because I knew she'd only laugh. And George—a disgusting wind-bag, an unscrupulous, hypocritical old hot-air merchant—a foul, poisonous self-advertiser—'

'Go on,' said Lord Caterham. 'I'm enjoying this.'

'My God!' said Bill simply and with feeling. 'Look here, I must be off.'

'No, no, don't go. I'd much rather you stayed. Besides, you want to see Bundle.'

'Not now. This has driven everything else out of my head. You don't know where Jimmy Thesiger is by any chance? I believe he was staying with the Cootes. Is he there still?'

'I think he went back to town yesterday. Bundle and Loraine were over there on Saturday. If you'll only wait—'

But Bill shook his head energetically and rushed from the room. Lord Catterham tiptoed out into the hall, seized a hat and made a hurried exit by the side door. In the distance he observed Bill streaking down the drive in his car.

‘That young man will have an accident,’ he thought.

Bill, however, reached London without any mischance, and proceeded to park his car in St James’s Square. Then he sought out Jimmy Thesiger’s rooms. Jimmy was at home.

‘Hullo, Bill. I say, what’s the matter? You don’t look your usual bright little self.’

‘I’m worried,’ said Bill. ‘I was worried anyway, and then something else turned up and gave me a jolt.’

‘Oh!’ said Jimmy. ‘How lucid. What’s it all about? Can I do anything?’

Bill did not reply. He sat staring at the carpet and looking so puzzled and uncomfortable that Jimmy felt his curiosity aroused.

‘Has anything very extraordinary occurred, William?’ he asked gently.

‘Something damned odd. I can’t make head or tail of it.’

‘The Seven Dials business?’

‘Yes—the Seven Dials business. I got a letter this morning.’

‘A letter? What sort of a letter?’

‘A letter from Ronny Devereux’s executors.’

‘Good Lord! After all this time!’

‘It seems he left instructions. If he was to die suddenly, a certain sealed envelope was to be sent to me exactly a fortnight after his death.’

‘And they’ve sent it to you?’

‘Yes.’

‘You’ve opened it?’

‘Yes.’

‘Well—what did it say?’

Bill turned a glance upon him, such a strange and uncertain one that Jimmy was startled.

‘Look here,’ he said. ‘Pull yourself together, old man. It seems to have knocked the wind out of you, whatever it is. Have a drink.’

He poured out a stiff whisky and soda and brought it over to Bill, who took it obediently. His face still bore the same dazed expression.

‘It’s what’s in the letter,’ he said. ‘I simply can’t believe it, that’s all.’

Chapter XXVIII

Suspicious

IT was just on the appointed hour of twelve o’clock that Bundle and Loraine entered the park gates, having left the Hispano at an adjacent garage.

Lady Coote greeted the two girls with surprise, but distinct pleasure, and immediately pressed them to stay to lunch.

O’Rourke, who had been reclining in an immense arm-chair, began at once to talk with great animation to Loraine, who was listening with half an ear to Bundle’s highly technical explanation of the mechanical troubles which had affected the Hispano.

‘And we said,’ ended Bundle, ‘how marvellous that the brute should have broken down just here! Last time it happened was on a Sunday at a place called Little Spedlington under the Hill. And it lived up to its name, I can tell you.’

‘That would be a grand name on the films,’ remarked O’Rourke.

‘Birthplace of the simple country maiden,’ suggested Socks.

‘I wonder now,’ said Lady Coote, ‘where Mr Thesiger is?’

‘He’s in the billiard-room, I think,’ said Socks. ‘I’ll fetch him.’

She went off, but had hardly gone a minute when Rupert Bateman appeared on the scene, with the harassed and serious air usual with him.

‘Yes, Lady Coote? Thesiger said you were asking for me. How do you do, Lady Eileen—’

He broke off to greet the two girls, and Loraine immediately took the field.

‘Oh, Mr Bateman! I’ve been wanting to see you. Wasn’t it you who was telling me what to do for a dog when he is continually getting sore paws?’

The secretary shook his head.

‘Oh, nonsense,’ said Jimmy. ‘You must get into the habit of believing six impossible things before breakfast. I do it regularly. Now then, let’s hear all about it. Wait a minute.’

He went outside.

‘Stevens?’

‘Yes, sir.’

‘Just go out and get me some cigarettes, will you? I’ve run out.’

‘Very good, sir.’

Jimmy waited till he heard the front door close. Then he came back into the sitting-room. Bill was just in the act of setting down his empty glass. He looked better, more purposeful and more master of himself.

‘Now then,’ said Jimmy. ‘I’ve sent Stevens out so that we can’t be overheard.

Are you going to tell me all about it?’

‘It’s so incredible.’

‘Then it’s sure to be true. Come on, out with it.’

Bill drew a deep breath.

‘I will. I’ll tell you everything.’

There was a moment's pause.

'And now I think I'll toddle back to bed,' said Jimmy. 'Night-night, Pongo.' With an affectation of nonchalance, he mounted the staircase. Rupert Bateman followed him. At the doorway of his room, Jimmy paused as if to say good-night once more.

'It's an extraordinary thing about these biscuits,' said Mr Bateman. 'Do you mind if I just—'

'Certainly, laddie, look for yourself.'

Mr Bateman strode across the room, opened the biscuit box and stared at its emptiness.

'Very remiss,' he murmured. 'Well, good-night.'

He withdrew. Jimmy sat on the edge of his bed listening for a minute.

'That was a narrow shave,' he murmured to himself. 'Suspicious sort of chap, Pongo. Never seems to sleep. Nasty habit of his prowling around with a revolver.'

He got up and opened one of the drawers of the dressing-table. Beneath an assortment of ties lay a pile of biscuits.

'There's nothing for it,' said Jimmy. 'I shall have to eat all the damned things. Ten to one, Pongo will come prowling round in the morning.'

With a sigh, he settled down to a meal of biscuits for which he had no inclination whatever.